

Emotional Reality Before Explanation: Conscious Feeling and Relevance for How to Proceed

Abstract

A consciously felt emotion can be present while its cause, meaning, fittingness, justification, appropriate response, or behavioral weight remains uncertain. This article develops a cross-literature identification architecture that keeps phenomenal occurrence separate from explicit self-interpretation, third-party interpretation, correctness or accuracy, justification, behavioral authority, and causal provenance. The architecture composes established work on emotion processing, awareness, appraisal, feelings-as-information, emotion rationality and fittingness, and validation; it does not claim those component distinctions as discoveries or propose a new mechanism or latent variable. Its scientific function is to prevent evidence for felt occurrence from silently substituting for evidence about these other relations. Paper-level originality remains open, and the architecture should contract if it adds no distinct identification work.

Keywords: emotion; conscious feeling; emotional awareness; emotion rationality; feelings-as-information; emotion understanding

1. Introduction: the problem is not whether the feeling makes sense

People often respond to emotion with statements such as “there is nothing to be upset about,” “that does not make sense,” or “I do not understand why you feel that way.” Those statements can challenge very different things. They can dispute an event description, reject a causal interpretation, question proportionality, criticize behavior, or simply report that one person cannot reconstruct another person’s internal state. Ordinary conversation frequently collapses those disagreements into a stronger conclusion: if the emotion cannot be explained well enough, perhaps it should not count as real.

That inference reverses the order of the problem. By the time a person can report fear, anger, hurt, distress, or an inchoate sense that something feels wrong, the consciously experienced state is already occurring. The explanation may be absent, partial, mistaken, or revised later. Another person may have a better model of the surrounding facts, or a worse one. None of those later epistemic facts is identical to the occurrence of the experience itself.

Emotion science already contains much of the machinery needed to state this precisely. Component-process and appraisal accounts distinguish event evaluation, physiological change, action tendency, conscious feeling, and categorization rather than treating them as one event (Moors et al., 2013; Scherer & Moors, 2019). Interoceptive and homeostatic accounts treat feeling as related to organismic states that are already being regulated (Carvalho & Damasio, 2021; Damasio & Carvalho, 2013). Constructionist accounts caution against assuming that a fully categorized emotion exists before all conceptual processing (Barrett, 2017). Emotion-awareness work distinguishes implicit or automatic processes from explicit awareness and describes capacities that may become available when emotion is consciously represented (Lambie, 2008; Lane, 2006; Ludwig, 2025; Smith & Lane, 2015). Emotion-understanding research separates understanding one’s own emotions from understanding a specific other or emotions more generally (Castro et al., 2016). Feelings-as-information research already shows that subjective feelings can enter judgment in ways moderated by attribution, relevance, salience, representativeness, and task

conditions (Greifeneder et al., 2011; Schwarz & Clore, 1983). Work on emotion rationality, fittingness, correctness, and epistemic assessability already distinguishes several standards by which emotions and their associated appraisals or responses may be evaluated (Deonna & Teroni, 2024; Magalotti & Kriegel, 2022; Naar, 2021; Pham, 2007; Scherer, 2011). Interpersonal validation research, including DBT-derived work, separately studies how validating or invalidating responses affect emotional reactivity and how validation can coexist with behavioral change (Kuo et al., 2022; Shenk & Fruzzetti, 2011).

The present article does not claim those components or distinctions as discoveries. Its narrower objective is to test whether they earn a useful cross-literature identification discipline around a recurring problem: once there is evidence for a consciously felt emotional state, which further questions remain separately unidentified?

The central proposal is that a felt emotional state can be real before the experiencer or anyone else fully understands it; that the feeling need not be a literal or complete account of the upstream processing that produced it; and that the state can nevertheless reflect an organism that is already non-neutral with respect to its circumstances, concerns, goals, preferences, regulation, or trajectory. In human language, the state carries relevance for **how to proceed from here**.

The article uses the word *request* for that how-to-proceed relevance. The term is deliberately metaphorical. It does not name a sender, receiver, neural message, module, or latent scalar. It does not mean “obey the feeling.” It compresses a family of already-established relations - valence, preference, discrepancy, goal progress, reward, uncertainty, action readiness, regulation, approach or avoidance - that remain scientifically distinguishable.

This framing permits a compact set of separations:

- emotional occurrence is not explicit understanding;
- occurrence is not causal explanation;
- felt reality is not interpretive accuracy;
- felt reality is not moral or interpersonal justification;
- felt reality is not behavioral authority;
- first-person experience is not first-person infallibility;
- third-party misunderstanding is not absence of experience;
- conscious feeling is not a transparent transcript of upstream organization;
- biological flexibility is not the same question as conscious flexibility;
- conscious availability does not, by itself, identify a unique mechanism or causal route.

These distinctions are the scientific object of the paper. The aim is not to add another emotion mechanism. It is to prevent valid evidence for one relation from being silently promoted into a conclusion about another.

2. Level of analysis: one organism, multiple relations

The architecture is organism-level and functional. It does not divide a person into “the body” and a separate conscious agent. There is one organism in which different processes make different information, states, and control possibilities available.

Before a feeling becomes explicitly reportable, organism-level processing may already have altered attention, autonomic state, action preparation, memory retrieval, expectancy, motivation, or physiological regulation. Component-process accounts explicitly describe emotion as differentiated activity across several interacting components rather than a single undivided state (Scherer & Moors, 2019). Smith and Lane (2015) likewise organize emotion generation, perception, and regulation as interacting levels rather than as a simple conscious-first sequence. Interoceptive accounts emphasize that physiological condition is continuously represented and regulated, while conscious feeling is one outcome of this broader organization (Carvalho & Damasio, 2021; Craig, 2002; Damasio & Carvalho, 2013).

This ordering should not be read as a universal serial pipeline. A constructionist account, for example, can assign conceptualization a constitutive role in the formation of particular emotion categories (Barrett, 2017). Appraisal theories differ in what is evaluated, when, and with what degree of automaticity (Moors et al., 2013; Scherer & Moors, 2019). The present argument therefore uses *understanding* narrowly: explicit interpretation of the consciously experienced state - its source, meaning, causal explanation, proportionality, implications, or appropriate response. It does not use *understanding* to mean every learned, conceptual, predictive, perceptual, or inferential process that may contribute to emotion generation.

That boundary matters. The claim is not that a fully formed fear or anger necessarily exists before any conceptual process. The claim is that a consciously experienced state need not wait for the person to possess a correct explicit explanation of why the state exists or what should follow from it.

This is also a measurement boundary. Phenomenal occurrence, verbal report, memory, behavior, autonomic change, and downstream control are related but nonidentical observables. A report can provide evidence about experience without becoming the definition of every process that produced it. Behavior can be influenced by affective organization without proving that the relevant state was consciously experienced. Conversely, the occurrence of a conscious state does not prove that it caused a later behavior. Where the same endpoint is compatible with common-upstream, parallel, or direct feeling-to-action organizations, the endpoint does not identify among them. Key and Brown (2024), for example, explicitly challenge the intuitive assumption that feelings must directly cause behavior and illustrate why causal role cannot be read from the ordinary sequence “I felt X, then I did Y.”

The architecture therefore begins with a modest discipline: **do not use one relation as a substitute measurement for another unless an independent bridge is supplied.**

3. Established foundations: processing, feeling, and non-neutral organization

3.1 Organism-level processing can precede explicit explanation

Emotion-process research already undermines the idea that explicit understanding must come first. Scherer and Moors (2019) describe an unfolding process in which appraisal, action tendencies, physiological responses, expression, conscious representation or feeling, and categorical labeling are

distinguishable components. Their account is not the only theory of emotion, but it provides a clear precedent for separating organism-level emotional organization from later semantic labeling.

Interoceptive approaches make a related point from a different direction. Craig (2002) describes interoception as representation of the physiological condition of the body. Damasio and Carvalho (2013) and Carvalho and Damasio (2021) place feeling within ongoing life regulation and interoceptive organization. Whatever position one takes on the stronger theoretical claims of these accounts, they make explicit that conscious feeling is embedded in regulation already occurring within the organism.

The immediate consequence is not a theory of consciousness. It is a constraint on inference. When someone says “I feel anxious, but I do not know why,” the absence of a correct explicit explanation does not imply that nothing has been processed. It indicates that a different relation - explicit causal or interpretive understanding - remains unresolved.

3.2 A feeling need not be a transcript of what produced it

A feeling can be vivid while its causal provenance is obscure. This should not be surprising if emotional experience is an integrated outcome of distributed processes rather than a readout containing a complete audit trail. Smith and Lane (2015) treat emotional perception and conceptual meaning as products of hierarchical processing that is not identical to the processes that generated the state. Constructionist and predictive accounts likewise make the relationship between internal state, prediction, categorization, and experienced emotion inferential rather than transcript-like (Barrett, 2017).

The phrase *not a transcript* is intentionally weaker than a positive representational theory. It does not claim that feeling is information-free, that it contains no causal information, or that one specific latent computation creates it. It states an identification limit: the fact that an experience is present does not establish that its conscious content contains a complete, literal, or uniquely decodable description of the upstream organization that contributed to it.

That limit protects both directions of inference. A person can be wrong about why they feel something without being wrong that the feeling exists. A third party can be correct about an external circumstance without thereby having exhaustive access to how that circumstance is currently experienced. The same felt report can be compatible with multiple upstream organizations, and the same upstream manipulation can produce different experienced outcomes across organisms or contexts. Those possibilities require additional measurement rather than stronger rhetoric.

3.3 The organism is already non-neutral

Once an emotional state is consciously felt, the organism is not in a neutral relation to every aspect of its current condition. What exactly has become non-neutral depends on the relevant theory and episode. Appraisal traditions emphasize relevance to concerns and evaluations of events (Moors et al., 2013; Scherer & Moors, 2019). Action-readiness traditions emphasize changes in readiness to maintain, alter, approach, avoid, or otherwise reorganize organism-environment relations (Frijda, 1987; Lowe & Ziemke, 2011). Control-process accounts relate affect to progress and discrepancy in goal-directed regulation (Carver & Scheier, 1990). Interoceptive and homeostatic accounts relate feeling to bodily condition and regulation (Carvalho & Damasio, 2021; Damasio & Carvalho, 2013). Active-inference approaches model behavior and homeostatic control through predicted states, policies, and adaptive regulation (Pezzulo et al., 2015).

These traditions should not be collapsed into a single mechanism. Their overlap is more modest: emotional and affective states are commonly analyzed in relation to significance for the organism - what is good or bad, desirable or aversive, congruent or discrepant, safe or threatening, progressing or obstructed, requiring maintenance or change.

That commonality is enough for the next step of the paper. The conscious feeling does not need to supply a perfect explanation to carry relevance. A person may know that something feels wrong before identifying which concern is implicated. They may experience attraction before articulating the preference. They may feel frustrated before recognizing that progress toward a valued goal has stalled. The experienced state can reveal that the organism is non-neutral while leaving the structure and source of that non-neutrality partly unidentified.

4. The central architecture: occurrence first, adjudication later

The simplest way to state the architecture is as a sequence of questions rather than stages in a biological pipeline.

First: **is there a consciously experienced emotional state?**

Second: **what is the state about, and why is it present?**

Third: **is the current interpretation accurate?**

Fourth: **what, if anything, does the state justify interpersonally, morally, or practically?**

Fifth: **what authority should the state have over what happens next?**

These questions can interact recursively. Interpretation can alter experience. Behavior can generate new evidence. Social response can alter later appraisal or regulation. Nothing here requires a one-way serial sequence. The scientific constraint is that an answer to a later question is not constitutive of the earlier phenomenal occurrence.

These questions also cross established vocabularies that should not be treated as interchangeable. In this article, accuracy refers operationally to correspondence between an interpretation and relevant evidence; philosophical work on correctness and fittingness addresses related but not identical evaluative standards; justification concerns whether the subject or a conclusion has adequate reasons under a declared epistemic, moral, or interpersonal standard; and behavioral authority is only an operational label for the weight assigned to the state in downstream action or regulation. None of these component distinctions is claimed as new (Deonna & Teroni, 2024; Magalotti & Kriegel, 2022; Naar, 2021; Pham, 2007; Scherer, 2011).

Table 1 summarizes the distinctions.

Table 1

Identification Targets and Evidential Limits

Question	Target relation	What a positive answer establishes	What it does not establish
Is an emotional state consciously present?	Phenomenal occurrence	The organism is undergoing the reported/felt state under the declared evidential bridge	Correct cause, accurate interpretation, justified behavior, unique mechanism

Question	Target relation	What a positive answer establishes	What it does not establish
Does the experiencer understand it?	First-person explicit interpretation	The person can supply a model of source, meaning, or implications	That the model is correct; that experience required the model to occur
Does another person understand it?	Third-party inference	The observer has a model that may fit available evidence	That the observer constitutes or directly measures the other's experience
Is the interpretation correct or accurate?	Correctness/accuracy relative to the declared target	The interpretation or emotion satisfies the relevant factual/evaluative criterion	That the feeling is more or less phenomenally real; that the subject is justified
Is the emotion, conclusion, or response justified?	Justification under a declared standard	The subject, conclusion, or response has adequate reasons under that standard	That the experience did or did not occur; that fittingness/correctness is thereby settled
How much weight should the feeling receive in behavior?	Behavioral weighting / authority	The state is assigned weight in action, delay, inquiry, communication, or regulation	That the state is infallible, uniquely controlling, or should always be obeyed
What caused the episode?	Causal mechanism/provenance	A causal route is identified under appropriate intervention and model assumptions	That the route follows from report or behavior alone

This table converts the ordinary slogan “feelings are real” into a bounded scientific claim. *Real* here refers to phenomenal occurrence under whatever evidential bridge a study legitimately uses. It does not mean that the experience transparently reports the external world. It does not mean that every interpretation attached to it is accurate. It does not mean that another person acted wrongly. It does not mean that immediate action is appropriate.

The distinction can be written compactly:

real ≠ understood ≠ accurate ≠ justified ≠ authoritative

The symbols are not algebra. They are a reminder that these are different predicates requiring different evidence.

5. First-person and third-party understanding are downstream of occurrence

Emotion-understanding research provides a useful precedent for separating who is doing the understanding. The EUREKA framework distinguishes emotion recognition and emotion knowledge across the self, a specific other, and people more generally (Castro et al., 2016). That taxonomy is not a theory of phenomenal occurrence, but it blocks an important collapse: understanding one's own emotional state and understanding another person's emotional state are different measurement targets.

The first-person case has a specific asymmetry. If a person is consciously undergoing an emotional state, they have direct phenomenal access to the occurrence in a way that an observer does not. That asymmetry does **not** grant privileged access to every cause. People can mislabel, misattribute, rationalize, or incompletely understand their emotions. The architecture therefore rejects both of the following inferences:

- “I cannot explain this feeling, therefore it is not real.”
- “I feel this, therefore my explanation must be correct.”

The third-person case has the complementary asymmetry. Another person may have superior information about external events, norms, hidden causes, or the history of an interaction. They may therefore correct an attribution or dispute an interpretation. But the observer’s success or failure at reconstruction is evidence about the observer’s model, not a constitutive condition for the target’s experience.

Consider fear. A person may truthfully report fear while incorrectly believing that another person intends harm. The fear can be real while the attribution of intent is false. An observer may correctly reject the threat interpretation while still acknowledging the emotional occurrence. This separation is not new to the validation literature. Experimental work shows that validating versus invalidating responses can alter affective and physiological reactivity, while DBT-derived accounts explicitly place validation within a dialectic that also includes behavioral change (Kuo et al., 2022; Shenk & Fruzzetti, 2011). The present architecture therefore treats acknowledgment without automatic endorsement as a PRECEDENTED interpersonal application, not as unoccupied territory.

This matters scientifically because agreement is not a universal measurement of another person’s phenomenology. If a study uses observer recognition, facial expression, autonomic response, or behavior as a proxy for a target’s conscious feeling, the bridge from that measure to phenomenal occurrence must be separately defended. The same discipline applies in the reverse direction: a first-person report of feeling is not a transparent measure of the exact upstream mechanism.

6. Occurrence is separate from correctness, justification, and behavioral authority

6.1 Occurrence is not correctness or accuracy

Emotion-rationality and fittingness literatures already treat emotions as assessable along standards that are not identical to phenomenal occurrence. Scherer (2011), for example, distinguishes the realism or accuracy of appraisal, appropriateness of response patterns, and efficacy of regulation; Pham (2007) reviews multiple conceptions of emotional rationality; and contemporary fittingness work analyzes whether an emotion is correct or appropriate relative to evaluative conditions (Deonna & Teroni, 2024; Naar, 2021). Rev2 therefore does not claim that separating occurrence from correctness is new. Its narrower identification rule is that evidence that an emotion is consciously felt does not, by itself, settle whether the associated appraisal, interpretation, or emotion satisfies the relevant correctness criterion.

This is where the not-a-transcript constraint becomes practical. A feeling can be phenomenally present while the interpretation attached to it is inaccurate, while the emotion is judged unfitting under one theory, or while the causal provenance remains unresolved. None of those outcomes requires the experience to be fictitious. Established emotion theories give no reason to grant feelings exhaustive transparency about the world or about their own upstream causes. The safer inference is that phenomenal occurrence and evaluative correctness require different evidence.

6.2 Occurrence is not justification

The distinction between an emotion’s correctness or fittingness and its justification is itself PRECEDENTED. Philosophical work explicitly separates whether an emotion meets a correctness or

fittingness condition from whether the subject has adequate reasons or evidence for it, while other work treats emotions as epistemically assessable in virtue of their evidence-responsiveness (Deonna & Teroni, 2024; Magalotti & Kriegel, 2022; Naar, 2021). The present paper therefore uses justification only as a separately typed question. A genuine experience can coexist with an unjustified attribution, conclusion, or response; conversely, a subject may have understandable evidence for an emotion that later proves inaccurate under a different standard.

The operational consequence is modest: a study or interpersonal judgment should state which standard is being assessed. Phenomenal occurrence, fittingness or correctness, epistemic justification, moral justification, and interpersonal warrant can overlap, but evidence for one cannot simply be renamed as evidence for the others.

6.3 Occurrence is not behavioral authority

Even a correctly interpreted or fitting emotion need not determine all-things-considered behavior. Fear may accurately track danger while approach is still chosen for a valued reason; anger may register a violation while immediate confrontation is strategically unwise; desire can be genuine and accurately identified while abstention remains preferable. Emotion-rationality work already evaluates response appropriateness and regulation, and feelings-as-information work already treats feeling as one source of judgment rather than an infallible command (Greifeneder et al., 2011; Pham, 2007; Scherer, 2011). Behavioral authority is therefore not proposed as a new construct. It is an operational label for the downstream question of how much weight the felt state receives among other evidence, goals, costs, norms, and control demands.

The distinction resonates with action-readiness work, which treats emotion and action tendency as closely related but not identical to realized action (Frijda, 1987; Lowe & Ziemke, 2011). It also fits regulatory-flexibility work showing that the adaptiveness of regulation depends on context, available strategies, and feedback rather than on one universally correct response (Bonanno & Burton, 2013).

The paper's "how to proceed" language is deliberately broader than action tendency for this reason. Sometimes the appropriate next move is to act. Sometimes it is to wait, gather information, communicate, reinterpret, inhibit, monitor, or do nothing immediately.

7. "Request" as how-to-proceed relevance

The word request is retained only as exposition. It is not part of the manuscript's residual scientific claim.

The term does **not** mean that "the body" sends a message to a separate conscious person. There is no second agent waiting to receive a biological instruction. Nor does it mean that the feeling contains a hidden command. The intended meaning is:

Request is shorthand for the consciously experienced relevance of an already-organized state to how the organism proceeds from its current condition.

Feelings-as-information research already owns the scientific proposition that subjective feelings can serve as information in judgment and that reliance on them depends on attribution, relevance, salience, representativeness, and task conditions (Greifeneder et al., 2011; Schwarz & Clore, 1983). The request metaphor therefore does not add a new information function. At most, it provides a readable umbrella for

the fact that an already-felt state may be relevant to what the organism does next, including whether it acts, waits, investigates, communicates, reinterprets, inhibits, or continues monitoring.

The components that can contribute to such relevance are established and heterogeneous. Table 2 summarizes these constructs.

Table 2
Established Constructs Contributing to How-to-Proceed Relevance

Established construct	What it contributes	Why it is not identical to “request”
Valence	Pleasant/unpleasant or good/bad organization of experience	Valence alone does not specify goals, cause, or response
Action readiness	Readiness to alter or maintain organism-environment relations	Readiness need not become action and does not cover all inquiry or interpretation
Goal discrepancy/progress	Relation between current and desired trajectory	Not all emotion is reducible to explicit goal progress
Reward/preference	What is sought, preferred, or reinforced	Preference is not identical to felt pleasantness or behavioral selection
Interoceptive/homeostatic organization	Relation to bodily condition and regulation	Does not by itself explain interpersonal meaning or every emotion category
Uncertainty/information need	Relevance of unresolved interpretation or prediction	Uncertainty can be cognitive without being emotional
Regulation	Processes that alter state, expression, behavior, or trajectory	Regulation can be flexible and nonconscious; it is not itself the felt state

The framework therefore makes no attempt to estimate a single latent request variable. A study concerned with judgment should use established feelings-as-information constructs; one concerned with action readiness, goal discrepancy, valence, uncertainty, preference, or regulation should measure those constructs directly. Request operates only at a human-readable level of synthesis.

This gives the metaphor a strict contraction rule. If it can be replaced everywhere by established constructs without loss of human intelligibility, it should be dropped. No paper-level originality depends on the word request surviving.

8. Biological flexibility and conscious flexibility are different questions

A common overcorrection is to argue that if nonconscious regulation can be flexible, conscious emotional availability has no distinct functional question left. That does not follow.

Biological regulation can adapt without conscious access. Habits, orienting, autonomic changes, learned cue responses, and other forms of regulation can vary with context and experience. Regulatory-flexibility work explicitly rejects the assumption that one strategy is uniformly adaptive and emphasizes sensitivity to context, repertoire, and feedback (Bonanno & Burton, 2013). Active-inference approaches likewise describe adaptive behavioral control without requiring that every regulatory variable be phenomenally represented (Pezzulo et al., 2015).

The scientific question about conscious flexibility is different: **what becomes possible when the state itself is consciously available?** Emotional-awareness theories and reviews propose several candidate

capacities. Lane (2006) distinguishes implicit and explicit emotional processing and treats conscious emotional awareness as a differentiated representational capacity. Lambie (2008) argues that awareness can permit emotional information to enter deliberation and support inhibition and reflective revision. Smith and Lane (2015) connect emotional awareness to hierarchical regulation and goal-directed action selection. Ludwig (2025) reviews evidence that conscious emotional processing can support more fine-grained evaluation, inhibition, and flexible response than corresponding unconscious processing.

These works precedent the component function. The present architecture does not claim that consciousness creates flexibility in general. It instead distinguishes two levels:

- **biological flexibility:** the organism adapts regulation or behavior without phenomenal access being required;
- **conscious flexibility:** the state itself becomes available to explicit interpretation, communication, comparison, inhibition, planning, or deliberate response revision.

The second level may matter even if the first is already sophisticated. A flexible automatic system can still lack explicit access to the fact that it is afraid, conflicted, attracted, or distressed. Conversely, explicit access can exist without guaranteeing effective control.

That final limitation is essential. Conscious availability is not the same as use, and use is not the same as authority. A feeling can be consciously present yet ignored. It can be considered yet outweighed by another goal. It can influence deliberation without determining action. It can correlate with later behavior because both share upstream causes rather than because the feeling directly caused the behavior. The framework therefore leaves the exact causal role of phenomenality open.

9. What conscious availability changes - and what it does not establish

Once a felt state becomes consciously available, it can become an object of explicit comparison. A person can compare fear with evidence of safety, immediate preference with long-term goals, anger with alternative interpretations, or reward with future cost. That does not mean the conscious process has privileged access to truth. It means that additional information can be brought into the same explicitly accessible problem space.

Lambie's (2008) notion of reflective revision captures part of this possibility, and Ludwig's (2025) functional analysis provides a contemporary precedent for inhibition and flexible response. The current framework uses those established ideas without treating them as evidence for a single causal mechanism. Conscious access may support comparison; it does not prove which neural route implements the comparison, whether the phenomenal state itself is the operative cause, or whether the same outcome could have been reached nonconsciously.

This distinction is particularly useful for apparent mismatch cases:

- "I am afraid, but I also have evidence that I am safe."
- "I want this, but I do not want the outcome that repeatedly follows."
- "I feel guilty, but I cannot identify an act that warrants guilt."
- "I am angry every time this happens, but I have not determined what expectation is being violated."

These are not episodes in which a separate mind corrects a mistaken body. They are episodes in which multiple states, models, goals, and evidence streams within one organism are simultaneously available. Subsequent behavior generates further information. The organism may update, maintain the existing organization, or remain conflicted.

Mindfulness is a useful illustration but not a proof of the architecture. A person can notice fear, refrain from immediate avoidance, consider other evidence, remain in a situation, and learn from what follows. That sequence is compatible with several established mechanisms - attention, decentering, extinction-related learning, reappraisal, inhibitory control, expectancy updating - and the present paper does not adjudicate among them. Its narrower point is that the felt state can remain present while the way of proceeding changes.

Accordingly, the paper distinguishes:

felt presence from **explicit access**, **access** from **use**, and **use** from **behavioral authority**.

Those distinctions are easy to lose when “conscious emotion” is treated as a single all-purpose variable.

10. Bounded reduction: how far does established theory already go?

A compositional paper must survive the possibility that its parts already explain everything of interest. Here, most positive component propositions are established. The strongest conventional reduction therefore grants those components first and asks whether any distinct paper-level scientific function remains.

10.1 Reduction to appraisal

Appraisal theories already explain how events can be evaluated in relation to concerns and how differentiated emotional responses can emerge (Moors et al., 2013; Scherer & Moors, 2019). If the present paper claimed that “emotions arise because things matter,” appraisal theory would largely subsume it.

Appraisal theory can supply upstream organization without by itself resolving every downstream question about phenomenal occurrence, self- or other-interpretation, correctness, justification, behavioral weighting, or causal provenance. Whether those remaining questions form a useful larger architecture can be assessed only after the additional reductions below are also granted.

10.2 Reduction to valence or action readiness

Valence and action-readiness accounts explain major dimensions of emotional significance and response preparation (Frijda, 1987; Lowe & Ziemke, 2011). If “request” meant only “urge to act,” the broader term would be unnecessary.

The proposed synthesis is wider because how-to-proceed relevance can include waiting, information seeking, interpretation, communication, inhibition, or continued monitoring. If empirical work shows that those additions are always epiphenomenal redescriptions of action readiness, the broader construct should contract.

10.3 Reduction to interoception and homeostasis

Interoceptive and homeostatic accounts strongly precedent the idea that feeling emerges within ongoing bodily regulation (Carvalho & Damasio, 2021; Craig, 2002; Damasio & Carvalho, 2013). They are therefore central grounding, not competitors to be displaced.

The present composition is not a claim that all emotion reduces to interoception. Its residual question concerns the relation among felt occurrence, explicit explanation, interpersonal understanding, and later adjudication. If a mature interoceptive theory already entailed and operationalized all of those distinctions for the same purpose, this paper would add little.

10.4 Reduction to emotion awareness and conscious access

Emotion-awareness theories and functional accounts of consciousness already supply much of the downstream story: explicit representation can support labeling, reflection, inhibition, communication, and flexible response (Lambie, 2008; Lane, 2006; Ludwig, 2025; Smith & Lane, 2015).

The present paper does not claim those functions as new. The remaining question is whether placing phenomenal occurrence before separately typed interpretive, evaluative, action-weighting, and causal questions prevents inferential substitutions that these component literatures do not themselves organize together.

10.5 Reduction to emotion understanding

EUREKA already distinguishes understanding emotions in the self, specific others, and people generally (Castro et al., 2016). That precedes the self/other measurement split. The manuscript therefore claims no novelty for separating those observers. Its only possible additional function is to place self- and third-party interpretation alongside phenomenal occurrence, evaluative correctness, justification, behavioral weighting, and causal provenance within one identification discipline.

10.6 Reduction to feelings-as-information

Feelings-as-information and affect-as-information traditions already establish that subjective feelings can be used as inputs to judgment rather than merely experienced passively. The classic mood-as-information result shows that affect can influence evaluative judgment and that attribution of the feeling to an irrelevant source can alter that influence (Schwarz & Clore, 1983). Greifeneder et al. (2011) further organize reliance on affective and cognitive feelings around salience, representativeness, relevance, evaluative malleability, and processing intensity. This literature substantially subsumes any scientific claim that the manuscript's request metaphor newly explains how feeling informs what happens next.

What remains, if anything, is not a new information function. The manuscript's candidate residual begins after granting that feelings can inform judgment: evidence for phenomenal occurrence and evidence that a feeling entered judgment still do not automatically identify the experiencer's explicit interpretation, a third party's interpretation, the emotion's correctness or fittingness, its justification, its all-things-considered behavioral weight, or its causal provenance.

10.7 Reduction to emotion rationality, fittingness, correctness, and justification

Emotion-rationality research already rejects a unitary question of whether emotion is simply rational or irrational. Scherer (2011) distinguishes appraisal accuracy or realism, response appropriateness, and

regulatory efficacy; Pham (2007) reviews logical, material, and ecological conceptions of rationality and documents both informative and biasing roles of emotion. Philosophical work separately analyzes fittingness or correctness, justification, and epistemic assessability (Deonna & Teroni, 2024; Magalotti & Kriegel, 2022; Naar, 2021). The components behind the manuscript's compact sequence are therefore strongly PRECEDENTED.

Accordingly, real $\neq$ understood $\neq$ accurate $\neq$ justified $\neq$ authoritative should not be read as a novelty slogan or as a claim that these terms form one established taxonomy. It is an identification reminder spanning several literatures. Accuracy, correctness, fittingness, justification, and action appropriateness have different technical meanings across theories; each must be operationalized under a declared standard. Behavioral authority is used here only for the downstream weighting question and carries no claim to a new normative category.

10.8 Reduction to interpersonal validation and invalidation

Validation/invalidation research already occupies the manuscript's interpersonal application. Shenk and Fruzzetti (2011) experimentally found different affective and physiological trajectories under validating versus invalidating responses. Kuo et al. (2022) define validation as communicating that another person's responses make sense within context and explicitly locate DBT within a dialectic that balances validation with behavioral change. Acknowledging emotional experience without automatically endorsing every behavior or interpretation is therefore PRECEDENTED rather than a contribution of this manuscript.

The residual, if any, is broader and cross-level: validation concerns an interpersonal response to another person's experience, whereas the proposed identification discipline also types first-person interpretation, third-party interpretation, correctness or fittingness, justification, behavioral weighting, and causal provenance as distinct questions that require their own evidence.

Granting all of these reductions removes any defensible claim to a new emotion mechanism, a new information function for feelings, a new correctness-versus-justification distinction, or a new validation principle. The strongest surviving candidate object is narrower: after evidence supports a consciously felt emotional occurrence, treat explicit self-interpretation, third-party interpretation, correctness or accuracy relative to a declared target, justification under a declared standard, behavioral weighting or authority, and causal mechanism or provenance as separately identified relations unless independent bridges are supplied. The manuscript's possible contribution is the systematic use of that set as one cross-literature identification discipline. The bounded prior-art search performed for this revision found strong neighboring frameworks but no source that clearly performs that entire same-level function. That absence is not proof of novelty; exact paper-level originality therefore remains OPEN.

11. Testable consequences and discriminations

The framework is theoretical, but it should change empirical questions. Several consequences follow.

11.1 Experience can precede correct explicit explanation

A study can sample a felt state close to its occurrence and separately assess the participant's explanation of source, meaning, or implication. Later access to additional information may improve explanation without changing the historical fact that the earlier state was reported. The important result would not be merely that explanations change; it would be a demonstrable dissociation between evidence of the earlier experience and the correctness of the explanation available at that time.

A weak version of this prediction is already familiar. The stronger empirical burden is to specify independent criteria for experience and explanatory accuracy so that one is not defined by the other.

11.2 Self-understanding and third-party understanding can vary independently

If self- and other-understanding are distinct targets, experimental designs should be able to manipulate information available to the experiencer and observer independently. An observer might receive contextual information that improves causal attribution while remaining unable to directly access phenomenal quality. Conversely, an experiencer may report a state accurately while lacking relevant external information. The framework predicts that these manipulations should alter understanding without constituting the presence or absence of the target experience.

11.3 “How to proceed” should decompose into established functions

Because feelings-as-information already explains a general route by which feelings can inform judgment, request has no independent mechanistic burden. If it is retained as readable synthesis, measured relevance should resolve into established dimensions or information-use relations rather than reveal a mandatory new latent factor. Across episodes, valence, action readiness, goal discrepancy, uncertainty, preference, attribution-sensitive judgment, and regulation may dissociate.

A failed decomposition - for example, if one established construct explains every useful prediction and the broader synthesis adds nothing - is a contraction result, not a reason to invent extra machinery.

11.4 Conscious availability should be tested against matched nonconscious alternatives

Claims that conscious availability adds explicit comparison or response capacity require more than observing that reported emotion predicts later behavior. The same behavior may arise from automatic regulation or common upstream processes. A strong design would require a validated manipulation or contrast that changes availability of the target state while preserving relevant upstream conditions closely enough to test differential access, interpretation, communication, inhibition, or revision.

Such a design is difficult because awareness manipulations can change the state itself, attention, task demands, or memory. The framework therefore does not claim that one simple experiment can isolate “the causal power of feeling.” It predicts a measurement problem: endpoint behavior alone will often be observationally equivalent across multiple latent organizations.

11.5 Response can change while the state remains present

The architecture predicts that changing how a person proceeds does not require erasing the original state. Fear can remain while avoidance decreases; anger can remain while immediate expression is inhibited; desire can remain while pursuit stops. The empirical burden is to measure the felt state and the changed response separately rather than infer one from the other.

11.6 Later understanding can revise trajectory without revising occurrence

A later reinterpretation can change future emotion, regulation, and behavior while leaving the historical occurrence of the earlier state intact. This predicts a useful asymmetry in longitudinal designs: later explanatory improvement may modify future responses without implying that the earlier report was “not real.”

12. Contraction and kill conditions

The architecture should be reduced if its distinctions do no work.

First, if explicit understanding in the narrow sense used here is shown to be constitutive of every conscious emotional occurrence, the core occurrence-versus-understanding distinction fails. Current theories do not warrant that universal claim, but the framework must remain vulnerable to it.

Second, if the felt state bears no measurable relation to valence, preference, goals, discrepancy, action readiness, uncertainty, regulation, or other forms of relevance, the “how to proceed” synthesis should contract. The paper does not need to preserve that language against contrary evidence.

Third, if consciously making an emotional state available adds no measurable capacity for explicit observation, communication, comparison, interpretation, inhibition, or response revision beyond matched nonconscious processing, the functional second half of the architecture should be reduced. The primary occurrence-versus-understanding distinction could survive that contraction.

Fourth, if the distinctions among reality, understanding, accuracy, justification, and authority change no measurement, prediction, intervention, or inferential error, they may be philosophically tidy but scientifically dispensable.

Finally, if existing work is shown to have already assembled substantially the same full composition for the same scientific purpose, the paper-level contribution is subsumed. Component precedent alone is not enough to establish that conclusion; most components are intentionally inherited.

13. Applications: acknowledgment without surrendering judgment

The interpersonal application is best treated as an extension of established validation work rather than a new principle. Validation research already studies the effects of communicating that another person’s emotional response is understandable in context, and DBT-derived models explicitly balance validation with behavioral change rather than treating validation as endorsement of every downstream action (Kuo et al., 2022; Shenk & Fruzzetti, 2011). The present architecture contributes only a more explicit cross-level typing of what is being acknowledged or disputed. Phrases such as “your feelings are valid” can still perform too many jobs at once: they may refer to occurrence, understandability, correctness, justification, or an owed response.

Separating the questions permits more precise statements:

- “I believe that you are afraid; I disagree that you are in danger.”
- “I believe that you are angry; I disagree that I intentionally harmed you.”
- “I understand that this boundary hurts; I still think the boundary is appropriate.”

These statements instantiate a distinction already familiar to validation traditions: acknowledgment of experience can coexist with change-oriented or evaluative disagreement. The additional discipline proposed here is to state which target is being assessed - occurrence, interpretation, correctness, justification, behavioral weighting, or causal provenance - rather than letting validation stand in for all of them.

Suppression and expression can also be placed correctly in the architecture. They are downstream ways of proceeding once a state exists; neither determines whether the state occurred. Suppression can be adaptive, maladaptive, or neutral depending on context, and the present paper requires no universal verdict. Likewise, comparisons with pain, fatigue, hunger, or craving are useful only at a structural level: a consciously experienced biologically relevant state can remain present while the eventual course differs from its immediate motivational tendency. Those domains are not one taxonomy and should not be treated as evidence for one shared mechanism.

Health consequences are therefore outside the core claim. Repeated response patterns can plausibly influence long-run biological trajectories through established routes such as sleep, avoidance, activity, social exposure, autonomic recovery, adherence, or substance use, but the present architecture neither requires nor identifies a unique disease pathway. The paper succeeds or fails before any health claim is added.

14. Limits

Several limitations are structural rather than temporary.

First, the paper does not identify a microscopic neural mechanism for emotional experience. Its level of analysis is functional and organismic. That is sufficient for the distinctions proposed here but insufficient for claims about implementation.

Second, first-person report is not a perfect meter of phenomenality. The framework relies on whatever evidential bridge a study can justify and does not solve the broader measurement problem of consciousness. The same caution applies to no-report measures, behavior, physiology, and neural correlates.

Third, the causal role of phenomenal feeling remains open. Covariation among feeling, action preparation, and behavior is compatible with direct causal influence, common causes, recurrent interactions, and other organizations. The architecture intentionally does not infer a unique route from the endpoint.

Fourth, request is an expository metaphor. Feelings-as-information and related work already own the general scientific proposition that feelings can inform judgment. Request should therefore be abandoned if it suggests a new information mechanism, invites sender-receiver dualism, or encourages researchers to collapse distinct constructs into a single invented variable.

Fifth, the paper does not adjudicate among appraisal, constructionist, interoceptive, homeostatic, active-inference, action-readiness, or control-process theories of emotion. It uses them as constraints and sources of established machinery. The architecture is viable only to the extent that its core distinctions remain compatible with multiple theories while still changing inference.

Sixth, paper-level originality remains OPEN. The bounded reduction in Section 10 identified strong prior ownership of feelings-as-information, emotional rationality/fittingness/justification, and interpersonal validation in addition to the literatures already granted by Rev1. No source reviewed in that bounded search clearly supplied the full same-function identification discipline, but absence of such a match is not evidence of novelty. The paper survives only if the composition changes measurement or inference beyond what those established components already accomplish.

15. Conclusion

An emotional experience does not become phenomenally present only when it is explained, validated by another person, judged fitting, or assigned behavioral weight. By the time a state is consciously felt, organism-level processing is already underway, and the feeling need not provide a complete transcript of that processing.

What the state establishes is bounded. Feelings-as-information research already shows that felt states can inform judgment; emotion-rationality and fittingness research already separates several standards of correctness, appropriateness, and justification; validation research already separates acknowledgment from behavior change. None of those established components, however, makes phenomenal occurrence, first-person interpretation, third-party interpretation, correctness or accuracy, justification, behavioral weighting, and causal provenance the same evidential target.

The phrase request can remain only as a human-readable umbrella for how-to-proceed relevance. It does not name a new function beyond those established literatures and it carries no paper-level novelty claim. If it obscures rather than clarifies the underlying constructs, it should be removed.

Conscious availability can make that already-real state available to explicit comparison with other evidence, goals, preferences, and outcomes. Yet conscious access does not create all flexibility, guarantee control, reveal ground truth, or identify a unique mechanism. Automatic biological regulation can also be flexible, and the causal role of phenomenality remains an empirical question.

The strongest surviving proposal is therefore an identification discipline:

after evidence for felt occurrence, do not substitute that evidence for self-interpretation, third-party interpretation, correctness or fittingness, justification, behavioral weighting, or causal provenance without an independently justified bridge.

Whether that cross-literature composition is itself original remains OPEN. Its scientific value depends not on owning its components, but on whether keeping them jointly separate prevents real inferential errors and changes what researchers measure, compare, intervene on, or refuse to conclude.

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